Goldman Sachs' Copper Outlook and BHP's $6 Billion Escondida Decision

Near-term earnings exposure, replacement economics and the case for conditional investment readiness

Executive summary / 5 November 2026

Independent SMPT research. Neither Goldman Sachs nor BHP commissioned, sponsored or endorsed this publication.

The question. How much should Goldman Sachs' bullish copper outlook change BHP's decision to commit roughly $6bn to Escondida's New Concentrator? The most useful answer separates the earnings exposed to a near-term price forecast from the operating value protected by a replacement asset. A stronger balance sheet can widen investment choices without making every copper project worth accelerating.

A material earnings difference. Public reporting puts Goldman's 2027 average copper forecast at $15,400/t, up from $13,800/t. BHP's disclosed FY2026 sensitivity translates that $1,600/t revision into a hypothetical $2.83bn underlying EBITDA differential on the unchanged historical portfolio. The $2,400/t gap between Goldman and the World Bank translates to $4.25bn on the same basis. These are useful measures of economic exposure, not 2027 earnings forecasts or cash immediately available for a project.

The investment question is continuity. The proposed plant replaces Los Colorados, which approaches the end of its operating life. Its 230-270ktpa facility output cannot be counted as wholly new mine production. BHP's 16-18% project return guidance uses a long-term copper assumption of $4.76/lb, approximately $10,494/t, and targets first production in 2031-32. The reported 2027 bank forecast does not establish returns over those later operating years.

Our judgment. Maintain funded engineering, permitting and conditional FID readiness. Selectively accelerate work that resolves critical uncertainty or protects a credible replacement schedule. Public information cannot rank construction acceleration against deferral on expected project value. The 199ktpa base capital-recovery result is too sensitive to unobserved life, cost and counterfactual assumptions to serve as a project viability verdict. The report uses it to show what management needs to substantiate.

Original finding	Financial significance
$2.83bn FY26-static EBITDA differential	Reported GS price revision at disclosed BHP exposure
$4.25bn same-scope spread	GS versus World Bank; no FCF conversion
199ktpa becomes 333ktpa in a shorter screen	Duration and the no-build baseline can dominate
Maintain funded readiness	Construction options need a verified counterfactual

Evidence: **S01** **S03** **S16** **S18**

1 / MARKET EXPECTATIONS

Goldman’s forecast contains a financing signal and a horizon mismatch

Keep comparable forecasts together. The annual-average comparison is $15,400/t for Goldman's reported 2027 forecast against the World Bank's $13,000/t October forecast, an 18.5% premium. The older reported Goldman average of $13,800/t provides the baseline for measuring its revision. A $14,405/t forward observation quoted in public coverage is a dated October 19 snapshot. It is neither a current tradable curve nor a consensus forecast.

US$/t, calendar 2027 average forecasts

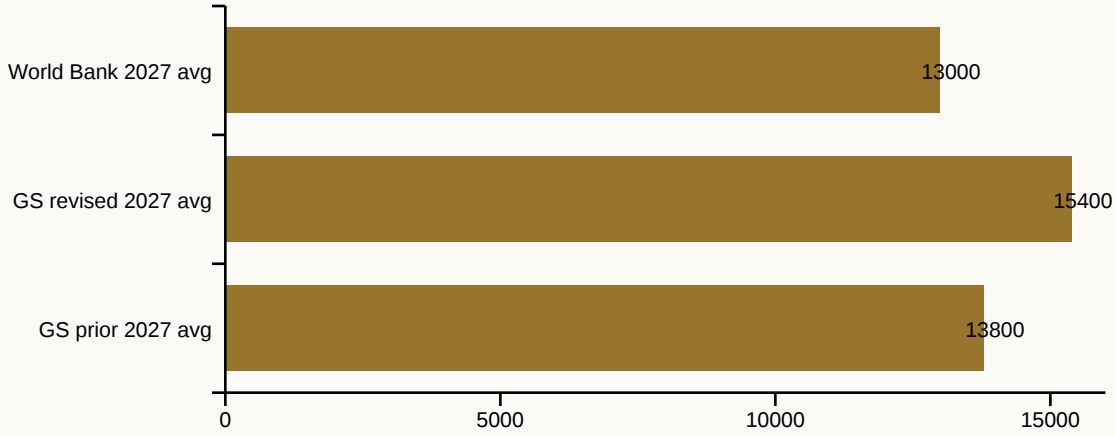


Exhibit 2. Goldman’s reported annual average is 18.5% above the World Bank’s. BHP long-term planning prices are excluded from this same-horizon chart.

Public bank evidence improves attribution. The original October 19 Goldman research report was not obtained. Substantive October 20 FinancialJuice coverage now verifies the public attribution of the $15,400 annual average, corroborating the earlier WII and ICAA accounts. Goldman itself published a separate October 23 podcast transcript in which Daan Struyven described a $15,600/t end-2027 view. That primary public statement confirms a bullish bank position but does not independently authenticate the proprietary note's annual-average number.

The planning price answers a different question. BHP identifies UBS May 2026 long-term consensus of $4.76/lb for its New Concentrator IRR. Its Copper cash-flow projections use $5.40/lb for FY2027-31 and $4.76/lb for FY2032-35. These issuer-disclosed assumptions belong to different investment and reporting horizons. Treating them as competing calendar-2027 price calls would misrepresent their purpose.

What the bank call can change. A higher realized price before construction can improve operating cash generation, dividend choices and access to internal funding. It can also raise construction inflation and the opportunity cost of disrupting existing production. The financial benefit depends on prices actually achieved, the quantity sold, tax and royalty responses, and distribution rights. The bank forecast affects those choices through a scenario, not through a guaranteed future cash receipt.

Evidence: **S12** **S16** **S18**

2 / INVENTORY, POLICY AND MARKET BALANCE

Regional scarcity can coexist with a projected global surplus

Two boundaries, two balances. ICSG's October 14 release projects global refined copper surpluses of about 104kt in 2026 and 368kt in 2027. Public Goldman reporting describes deficits outside the United States of 950kt and 220kt, respectively. These are different geographic and accounting universes. They cannot be netted into a residual shortage or used alone to conclude that either institution is wrong.

Refined balance kt; distinct geographies and forecast methods

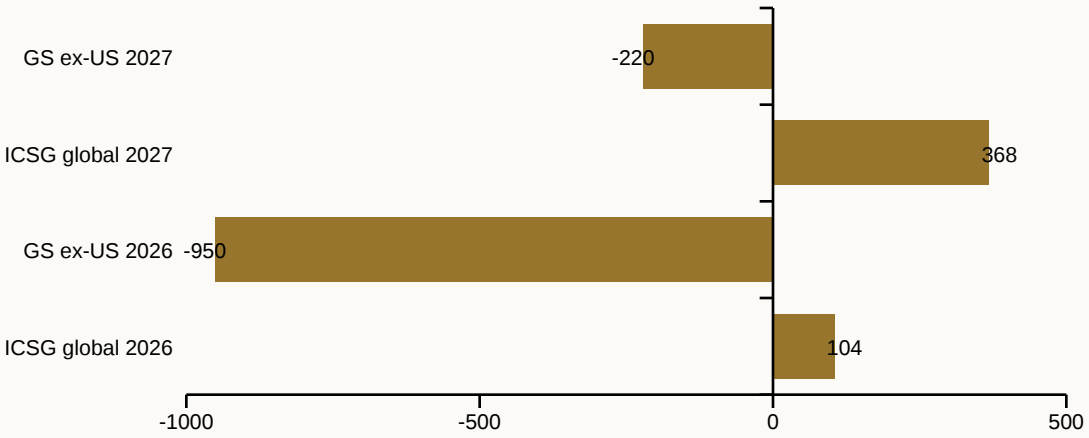


Exhibit 3. Global and ex-US balances describe distinct markets. Their difference is not an estimated US surplus.

Inventory location transmits policy uncertainty. Goldman's public explanation links US import and stockbuilding incentives to prospective tariffs, with Chinese scrap weakness increasing demand for refined metal. Copper moving into US warehouses may become less readily available elsewhere without disappearing from the global stock balance. A reversal in inventory incentives can loosen regional availability even if electrification demand continues to grow. Commercial price formation depends on available metal, location and timing as well as annual global output.

The official forecast also has an inventory caveat. The primary ICSG release notes that its China apparent-use calculation does not capture changes in unreported stocks. That limitation matters during stockbuilding or destocking. Forecast signs and small annual balances therefore deserve less confidence than their apparent numerical precision might suggest.

Financial transmission, not an assumed policy profit. For BHP, regional tightness can affect benchmark prices, physical premiums, freight and treatment terms. This study changes copper prices in its operating sensitivity but does not attribute a dollar profit to a specific tariff. Nor does it equate duties on copper articles and derivatives with a blanket refined-metal tariff. The strongest investment implication is the possibility of volatile near-term margins and funding conditions, not proof of a permanently higher long-term price.

Evidence: **S16** **S18** **S19**

3 / BHP FINANCIAL EXPOSURE

Copper’s earnings contribution grew despite lower reported output

Financial materiality is already observable. BHP's statutory Copper segment reported FY2026 revenue of $29.031bn and underlying EBITDA of $18.187bn, against $22.530bn and $12.326bn in FY2025. The revenue increase was $6.501bn and EBITDA increase $5.861bn. Group copper production fell from 2.017Mt to 1.953Mt while average realized copper rose from $4.25/lb to $5.74/lb. These observations establish large earnings exposure but are not a complete causal price-volume-cost bridge.

Underlying EBITDA, US$bn; statutory segments

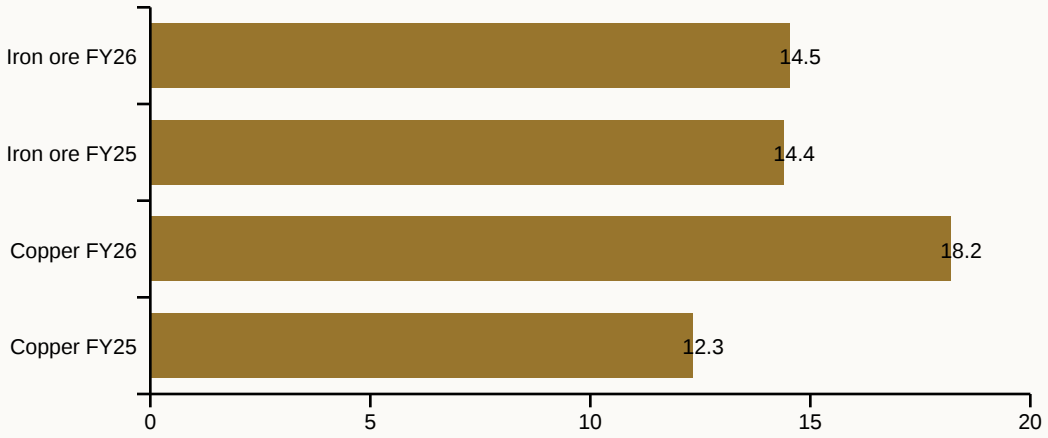


Exhibit 4. Copper EBITDA rose strongly while iron ore changed little. This is an observed result, not a causal price bridge.

The 54% headline has a defined denominator. BHP's copper contribution excludes Group and unallocated items. Copper divided by Copper, Iron Ore and Coal EBITDA gives 54.2%, rounding to the disclosed 54%. Copper divided by the $32.947bn group total gives 55.2%. Both calculations are valid, but they answer different questions. The distinction prevents an apparent reconciliation error and keeps subsequent materiality comparisons on the same basis.

Asset and statutory presentations differ. Escondida is fully consolidated because BHP controls the subsidiary, despite holding 57.5% economically. Antamina is equity accounted. Asset-management tables can show a different combination of venture-share revenue and earnings from the statutory reportable-segment table. A universal ownership haircut across reported copper revenue, EBITDA and production would corrupt that accounting boundary.

Earnings concentration is not a capital mandate. A higher copper contribution strengthens the strategic relevance of execution and replacement at existing assets. It does not prove that the next marginal copper dollar dominates iron ore, potash, distributions or debt reduction. Capital allocation should compare incremental risk-adjusted benefits and obligations. Historical earnings from a high-quality asset are evidence of funding capacity and exposure, not a substitute for the proposed project's counterfactual economics.

Evidence: **S02** **S03** **S05**

4 / ORIGINAL OPERATING ANALYSIS

The disclosed sensitivity gives a $2.83bn illustration of Goldman’s revision

Start with the company’s exposure measure. Slide 48 of BHP's FY2026 presentation reports an approximate $39m change in underlying EBITDA for a US cent/lb change in copper. The footnotes refer to the existing portfolio and total exposed volume, excluding equity-accounted investments. Converting dollars per metric tonne to cents per pound yields a directly reproducible static exposure calculation.

Hypothetical FY26-static EBITDA delta, US$bn vs $13,800/t

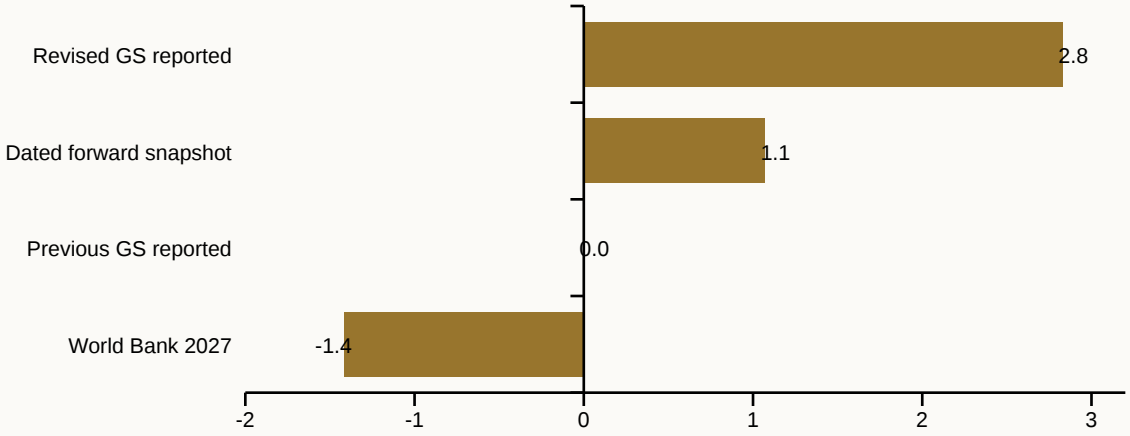


Exhibit 5. Original calculation using BHP’s disclosed FY26 sensitivity, relative to the older reported $13,800/t forecast. Not a 2027 earnings forecast.

Magnitude and inference. The reported $1,600/t revision equals 72.575 US cents/lb. Multiplication by $39m produces $2,830.416m. The Goldman-World Bank gap of $2,400/t gives $4,245.625m on the same scope. The difference is financially meaningful, but applying a local sensitivity across a large shock assumes linear behavior and an unchanged historical portfolio. It does not incorporate future grades, production, price-linked costs, contract terms or fiscal changes.

The counterfactual is a price comparison. The reference $13,800/t is the older reported Goldman calendar-2027 forecast, not BHP's realized FY2026 copper price. The calculated amounts therefore cannot simply be added to FY2026 reported EBITDA to create a 2027 forecast. Their purpose is to express how economically different the price expectations are at a common disclosed exposure scale.

Use the sensitivity at the right decision level. This is the strongest public first-pass quantitative link between the bank's forecast and BHP earnings. It helps assess whether financing conditions could improve materially under a bullish price outcome. Tax, working capital, minority distributions, financing and other commodities determine the amount reaching parent discretionary cash. The workbook deliberately stops short of converting the issuer sensitivity into a forward FCF or EPS forecast.

Evidence: **S01** **S12** **S18**

5 / EXPOSURE RECONCILIATION

A lower-volume proxy is informative, but does not reconcile exactly

Why the exposure measures differ. An illustrative FY2027-scale proxy uses FY2027 asset guidance midpoints totaling 1.575Mt for consolidated operations, multiplied by a 95% payable/sales factor and a 5% price-linked leakage assumption. The $1,600/t change then produced $2.394bn of gross sales exposure and a $2.274bn EBITDA proxy. That proxy is about 19.6% below the company's $2.830bn FY2026-static sensitivity illustration.

Different bases explain why equality is not expected. The company sensitivity describes historical FY2026 exposure. The alternative proxy scales a future fiscal-year production guide and imposes assumed sales conversion and cost responses. Published group production combines 100% subsidiaries with BHP-share equity-accounted production. The asset midpoint sum, including Antamina separately, is 20kt below the group guidance midpoint, which does not require a numerical plug. Public information does not permit an exact exposed-sales and contract reconciliation.

The latest quarter challenges the windfall framing. BHP's Q1 FY2027 realized copper price was a provisional $7.01/lb, about $15,454/t, while output fell 19% year on year to 400.7kt. Goldman's reported 2027 average is already close to that realized price. The outlook can support the persistence of strong margins without implying another comparable step-up from the latest quarter. Realized pricing includes finalization effects and differs from an LME annual benchmark.

Appropriate decision use. The analysis leads with BHP's disclosed sensitivity and retains the lower-volume proxy as a diagnostic. The corresponding $1.48bn cash proxy requires an assumed marginal tax rate and cash realization. It does not establish parent funds available for investment. Funding conclusions should instead draw on reported cash uses, disclosed management scenarios and the legal and economic boundaries around mine cash.

Comparison	Scope / result
Issuer FY26 sensitivity	Existing consolidated exposure; $2.830bn EBITDA illustration
Illustrative FY27-scale proxy	1.575Mt x95% sales x95% pass-through; $2.274bn
Exact reconciliation	Unavailable: contracts, exposed sales and response differ
Decision use	Lead with issuer sensitivity; no inferred funding forecast

Evidence: **S01** **S03** **S05**

6 / ASSET, SCOPE AND DEVELOPMENT STAGE

Escondida is a replacement investment with a changing design envelope

What BHP proposes. The New Concentrator replaces Los Colorados. March disclosure described $4.4-5.9bn of capital and 220-260ktpa of copper output. By August, guidance was $5.4-6.3bn and 230-270ktpa, with throughput increased by 10% to 50Mtpa. The capex midpoint increased 13.6%, from $5.15bn to $5.85bn, against a 4.2% rise in the copper-output midpoint. Design maturity and scope changed, so the comparison is not evidence of a construction-stage overrun.

Gross cost, economic interest and funding authority. BHP owns 57.5% of Escondida, Rio Tinto 30% and JECO interests 12.5% combined. The gross budget implies $3.105-3.623bn on a simple BHP pro rata economic basis. That calculation is not a verified parent contribution schedule. The August approximately $0.5bn readiness figure is BHP share; October's $0.8bn is gross. They are not additive and neither authorizes the full project.

Readiness is a separate decision. BHP targets FID in CY2027-28 and first production in CY2031-32. The publicly indexed Chilean file remains under evaluation with RCA pending. It records October 9 additional questions, an October 14 extension and a November 4 applicant request to extend suspension. The last is a request, not proof that an extension was granted. Substantive October official documents were not reliably accessible, so no delay probability or adverse environmental finding is inferred.

Why the physical counterfactual matters. The value comparison must specify how much production would be lost without the replacement, which ore could be processed through alternatives, and the cost of sustaining or retiring existing capacity. Some output may be preserved and some added through higher throughput or recovery. Neither zero benefit because the project is replacement nor 250ktpa of wholly incremental mine output is a defensible default.

Development milestone	Evidence and financial meaning
17 March 2026 announcement	$4.4-5.9bn; replacement plan
18 August investor estimates	$5.4-6.3bn nominal; 16-18% issuer IRR
20 October operating review	$0.8bn gross readiness approval; full FID still ahead
4 November filing indexed	Applicant extension request; no inferred approval
CY2027-28 / CY2031-32	Target FID / first production, subject to gates

Evidence: S01 S05 S06 S07 S17

7 / INVESTMENT SCREEN

Reverse appraisal asks what benefit would recover the assumed capital

A useful question with a limited claim. The public record lacks the annual project cash-flow schedule needed to replicate BHP's 16-18% IRR. We instead reverse the investment question: under transparent assumptions, what levelized annual benefit would recover capital at a chosen discount rate? This identifies the evidence needed to justify an investment. It cannot establish the actual project's value or BHP's internal hurdle rate.

Base construction. The screen assumes $5.85bn of nominal gross capital, evenly paid at year ends 2027-31, a 10% nominal discount rate and 20 full benefit years from 2032. Discounted capital at end-2026 is $4.435bn and the benefit annuity factor is 5.286. The required after-tax benefit is consequently $839m a year. Full budget is included because readiness approval does not identify a reliably sunk amount.

Translate money into an equivalent operating benefit. At $10,494/t copper, a hypothetical $4,000/t all-in net cash burden and a 35% cash-tax wedge leave about $4,221/t of after-tax contribution. Dividing $839m by that margin gives 198.8ktpa. This is a levelized equivalent of production preserved or added relative to a no-build case. It is not BHP's disclosed production target, a required recovery percentage, or an independently estimated mine benefit.

The economic boundary is broader than tonnes. A complete comparison also includes avoided old-plant spending, operating-cost differences on production that survives either way, tax depreciation, by-products, closure, working capital, leases and commercial commitments. Those terms can materially change the required copper-equivalent benefit. The assumed all-in burden is not Escondida's C1 cost and is not an engineering estimate. The production translation is a communication device for the capital-recovery equation.

Screen input or result	Base case
Gross nominal capital / present value	$5.850bn / $4.435bn
Discount / benefit convention	10% nominal / 20 full years from 2032
Required annual after-tax benefit	$839m
Assumed after-tax contribution	$4,221/t at $10,494 price and $4,000 burden
Equivalent benefit / facility midpoint	198.8ktpa / 250ktpa; counterfactual unmeasured

Evidence: **S01**

8 / SENSITIVITY AND COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS

The production hurdle moves materially with life, margin and price

The 199ktpa result is not robust enough to be a verdict. The base equals roughly 80% of a 250ktpa facility midpoint. The combined stress reaches 416ktpa using $8,500/t long-term copper, a 20% capital increase and two years of benefit deferral. Arithmetic alone cannot show that BHP lacks sufficient benefit in either case. Other cash benefits, counterfactual costs and actual operating life remain unobserved.

Required equivalent benefit (ktpa) by long-term copper price (US$/t)

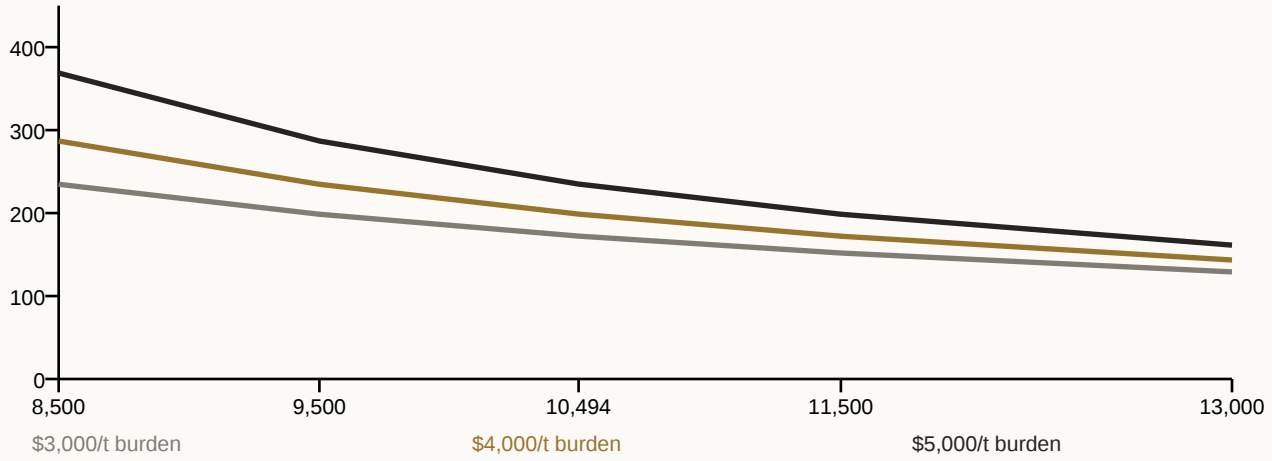


Exhibit 9. Required equivalent benefit changes with both price and the assumed net cash burden. All curves use five equal capital draws, 20 benefit years and a 10% discount rate.

Benefit duration changes the conclusion. The base assumes 20 years of full benefits beginning in 2032. BHP's disclosed facility range is an average over FY2034-43, not a 20-year flat production schedule. If the screen credits only 10 benefit years beginning in 2034, the required equivalent rises to about 333ktpa at otherwise unchanged assumptions. This is not an alternative company mine-life forecast. It shows how extrapolating beyond the disclosed averaging window changes the result.

Margins matter as much as the headline copper call. At the base long-term price, reducing the assumed net burden from $4,000/t to $3,000/t lowers the required equivalent benefit to about 172ktpa. Raising it to $5,000/t increases the hurdle to about 235ktpa. Price and cost jointly determine contribution, and that relationship becomes nonlinear as price approaches burden. A point estimate of preserved tonnes without a credible margin schedule is therefore inadequate.

A stronger use of the screen. Ask management to demonstrate the no-build lost-production and avoidable-cost bridge across a range of realistic margins and durations. A replacement case becomes stronger when continuity losses are large and alternatives expensive. It becomes weaker when alternative circuits preserve output at low cost or when grade, cost and schedule erode the new facility's benefit. This framework remains useful even when a single project valuation cannot be defended.

Evidence: **S01**

9 / EXECUTION AND THE VALUE OF READINESS

Delay is costly only through a specified operating counterfactual

Separate delay from deferral. A construction delay can leave spending in place while benefits arrive later. A deliberate deferral can move both spending and benefits and change escalation, procurement and continuity risk. The one-year delay case holds capital timing fixed and increases the levelized benefit hurdle by 10%, to 219ktpa. That is a discounting illustration, not a prediction of the mine's lost copper or a priced permit outcome.

Required equivalent benefit, ktpa; other base assumptions fixed

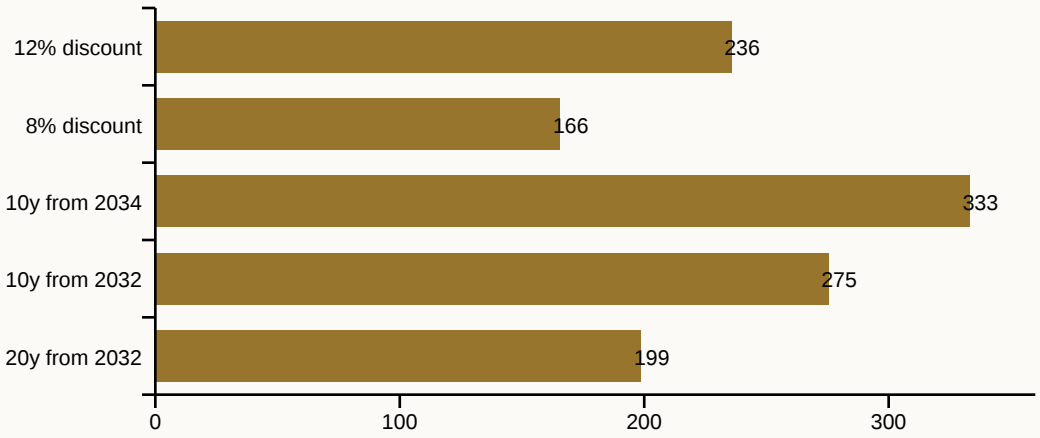


Exhibit 10. The disclosed FY34-43 averaging window does not substantiate twenty flat benefit years. All results are hypothetical screens.

The option comparisons are conditional identities. A one-year acceleration of both capital and benefits with a 10% cost premium raises the required annual benefit by 10%. A one-year shift of both with 5% escalation raises it by 5%. The timing discount largely cancels because both sides move together. Those results do not independently prove that staging is optimal. They restate assumed premiums and omit the operating counterfactual that could dominate them.

Quantify the condition, not an invented loss forecast. At the base assumed net margin, 125ktpa of production lost for one year would represent about $528m of after-tax benefit. If the mine can avoid that loss through rerouting or limited sustaining work, the economic cost of deferral falls. If retiring capacity creates a larger, longer interruption, it rises. The 125ktpa is a scenario input, not an observed Los Colorados decline profile.

Where acceleration can be justified now. Engineering definition, permitting responses, long-lead assessment and safe interface planning can reduce uncertainty before full sanction. Their value comes from improving the eventual decision and protecting a feasible schedule. Construction acceleration requires a permitted, executable plan and evidence that avoided continuity losses exceed extra cost and risk. The current record supports continued readiness work more strongly than it supports a universal construction-speed recommendation.

Evidence: **S01** **S05** **S17**

10 / CORPORATE CAPITAL ALLOCATION

Funding evidence supports flexibility, not a project cash forecast

Start with cash actually reported. BHP generated $21.778bn of operating cash flow and incurred $12.011bn of net investing outflow in FY2026, giving $9.767bn of reported free cash flow. BHP cash dividends were $6.756bn and NCI dividends $2.355bn. Subtracting those cash distributions leaves $0.656bn before other financing items. This is a historical cash-use observation, not a forecast of residual funding capacity.

FY2026 consolidated cash-use measures, US$bn

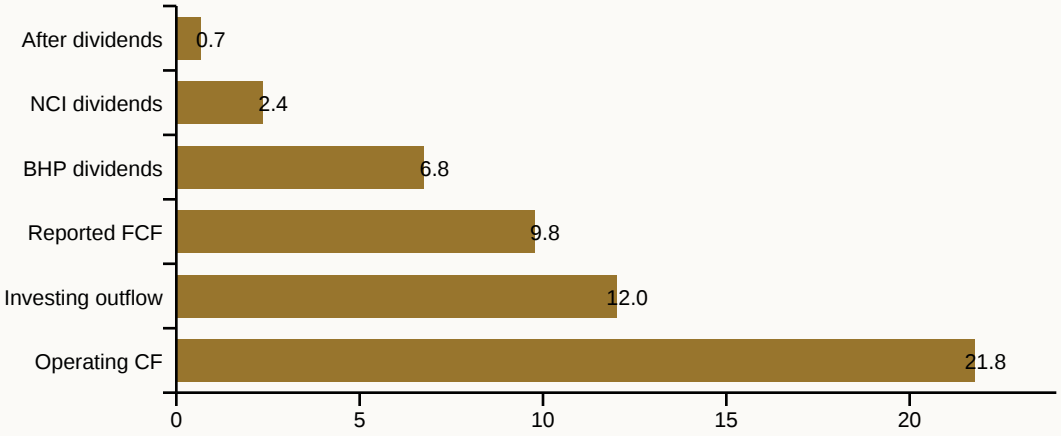


Exhibit 11. Reported FY26 FCF already includes investing outflows. Cash after dividends is a historical subtotal before other financing, not future project funding.

Do not turn monetization into recurring operations. The $4.3bn Antamina silver-streaming receipt sits in financing activities as a liability-related inflow. It improved liquidity and net debt but encumbers future by-product economics. Historical net debt was $8.694bn, cash $18.532bn and the undrawn RCF $5.5bn. Cash includes restrictions and subsidiary interests, while a debt target is a policy choice rather than a committed credit facility. Those figures inform flexibility without establishing an immediately deployable project allowance.

Management has already modeled investment spending. BHP's Copper projections show approximately $12bn of cumulative attributable FCF for FY2027-31 and $24bn for FY2032-35 at its assumptions. They already include modeled capital and NCI distributions, with specified centralized interest and taxes outside segment figures. They are not annual guidance and should not have New Concentrator capex deducted again. They support management's self-funding claim under its scenario, not an independent assurance that every year or stress case is funded.

Portfolio discipline still matters. Group capex and exploration guidance is approximately $11bn annually through the medium term. Copper SA, Vicuña, Spence, potash and sustaining needs compete for sequencing and execution capacity. Jansen Stage 2's total estimate increased to $6.9bn from $4.9bn. Project budgets differ in ownership, nominal versus real dollars and remaining versus total spend. Their headline amounts cannot be summed into a current funding gap or ranked as investment returns.

Evidence: **S01** **S02** **S03**

11 / STRATEGY AND DECISION TRIGGERS

Maintain conditional FID readiness; earn the case for faster construction

The recommendation follows the evidence hierarchy. Continue the funded pre-FID program and preserve the planned replacement timetable, subject to normal permit, engineering and return gates. This is more defensible than an unconditional acceleration or a predetermined project delay. It recognizes the potential cost of losing existing capacity and the absence of the information needed to quantify it. The stylized option screens cannot establish a preference for staging on their own.

What would justify acceleration. A credible operating plan showing near-term retirement losses that cannot be managed through alternative processing would strengthen the value of earlier completion. Acceleration also needs approved permits, safe interfaces, available suppliers and a costed schedule. Evidence that those avoided losses exceed the incremental execution premium would provide a financial case. A higher 2027 price forecast by itself does not satisfy those conditions.

What would justify staging or re-scoping. Commitment should slow if a more mature estimate, verified fiscal schedule or realistic recovery profile fails BHP's applicable return test, or if permits and design leave major irreversible work exposed to rework. Staging becomes more attractive when low-cost alternatives protect production and portfolio obligations constrain cash. There is no disclosed internal hurdle rate or complete project model here with which to assert that those conditions already hold.

The next highest-value information. The most useful additional dataset is an annual with-build versus no-build mine plan: payable copper, alternatives, sustaining cost and closure, followed by the associated tax and capital schedule. That would convert the reverse-appraisal questions into an investment comparison. More near-term bank price targets would improve market context, but are less likely to resolve the central sanction question than that counterfactual operating evidence.

Course of action	When financially defensible
Maintain readiness	Replacement need credible; preserve permitted engineering path
Accelerate selected work	Costed avoided continuity loss exceeds premium; safe and permitted
Stage or re-scope	Return/readiness gap persists and alternatives protect output
Defer major construction	Complete counterfactual demonstrates option value exceeds lost benefit

Evidence: **S01** **S03** **S05** **S17**

12 / METHODS AND RESEARCH LIMITS

The research supports a decision framework, not independent project valuation

Reproducibility. The editable workbook retains six selectable cases, historical financials, a disclosed-sensitivity module and a separately labeled investment screen. Formula propagation is checked against Python calculations. Standalone CSVs provide the price sensitivity, price-cost frontier and duration cases used in the report. Monetary outputs use unrounded calculations and display rounding only. Model year-end discounting uses end-2026 as the valuation origin.

Evidence hierarchy. Historical facts and corporate guidance come principally from BHP's annual report, results presentation and operating updates. Forecasts retain their institutional attribution and stated horizon. The Goldman annual-average forecast relies on public secondary reporting; the bank's public transcript independently supports a related end-year view. The ICSG balance uses its primary October release. Environmental review status uses an indexed mirror and is assigned lower evidentiary weight.

Scope of the original contribution. The original work puts rival price expectations on BHP's common disclosed earnings-exposure scale and tests the assumptions required to translate a replacement budget into operating benefit. The 199, 333 and 416ktpa results are reverse-appraisal sensitivities, not estimated project output or an independent investment rating. A forward funding residual is omitted because mixed reporting periods and cash-conversion assumptions would create a misleading appearance of precision.

Editorial assessment. READY FOR EDITORIAL REVIEW as independent financial and corporate-strategy research. Missing no-build production, project fiscal and cash schedules prevent an independently valued investment case or lending conclusion. The original Goldman note remains inaccessible, but the annual-average attribution has credible public corroboration and related primary bank commentary. Permit metadata is mirror-based and requires a publication-date refresh. Internal agent review and arithmetic checks are not external professional assurance. Public release, sharing changes and website deployment remain separately authorized actions.

Research result	Decision boundary
Comparable price-exposure calculation	FY26-static EBITDA illustration, not future FCF
Reverse appraisal of replacement benefit	No independently measured with/without-build production
Historical cash and management projections	Different periods and scopes stay separate
Conditional readiness framework	Construction options require a complete counterfactual

Evidence: **S01** **S03** **S16** **S18** **S19**

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Inspect the evidence and reproduce the analysis

The evidence register distinguishes source documents from access attempts. The claim matrix links major conclusions to document locators and separates reported facts, forecasts and original assumptions. Original bank research is not redistributed.

S01 / BHP. FY2026 results presentation. 2026-08-18. Slides 19-22, 28, 35-36, 40, 48, 50. Verified primary.

S02 / BHP. FY2026 results exchange release. 2026-08-18. PDF pp. 4-5, 7, 19, 21-24. Verified primary.

S03 / BHP. Annual Report 2026. 2026-08-18. PDF pp. 22, 30, 36-37, 132, 136, 153, 163-165. Verified primary, selected sections.

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S06 / BHP. Escondida asset page. Undated; retrieved 2026-11-04. Escondida at a glance. Verified primary.

S07 / BHP. Environmental permit submission announcement. 2026-03-17. Project description. Verified primary.

S08 / World Investment Institute. Copper: Goldman Sachs Raises Price Forecast on US-China Competition. 2026-10-25. Forecast table; market mechanisms; risks. Verified public secondary, original unavailable.

S09 / International Copper Association Australia. Copper Weekly Brief - 22 October 2026. 2026-10-22. Supply and demand outlook table. Verified public secondary.

S12 / World Bank. Commodity Markets Outlook, October 2026. 2026-10-27. Table 1, PDF p.21 (printed p.13). Verified primary.

S16 / Goldman Sachs. Exchanges: Why Oil Prices Are Surging Despite Recovering Supply. 2026-10-23. Transcript, copper exchange with Daan Struyven. Verified primary transcript.

S17 / Ambi / SEA indexed documents. Escondida SEIA file 2167965265. Retrieved 2026-11-05. Project metadata; ICSARA2; extension request. Mirror inspected; underlying October text inaccessible.

S18 / FinancialJuice. Goldman Sachs: Copper - FJElite. 2026-10-20. 20Oct 08:37 article body. Substantive public secondary text inspected.

S19 / ICSG. Copper Market Forecast 2026/2027. 2026-10-14. Linked two-page release, p.1 balance paragraph and methodology. Primary PDF body inspected via catalog download.

S20 / Business Recorder / Reuters. Copper flat as China caution outweighs US stockpiling, Goldman upgrade. 2026-10-20. Goldman forecast paragraph. Public article inspected.

Working model. Native Google Sheet. **Research baseline.** PR #202. Supporting methods, evidence, calculations and the executive deck are included in the private delivery folder.

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